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New media become mouthpiece for RFK Jr.

PAC recruits influencers to plug profound changes

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Robert F. Kennedy Jr. is no longer running for office and his confirmation battle to be health secretary is long-since won.

Now, as Kennedy wields the tools of government to dramatically reshape public health policy and its vast federal bureaucracy, the big money political group that helped propel his political rise has switched gears, spending to cultivate a media ecosystem that advances Kennedy's policy goals.

Known now as MAHA PAC, after Kennedy's adoption of the pro-Trump "Make America Healthy Again" slogan, the political committee is paying hundreds of thousands of dollars to social media influencers and writers to contribute to a Kennedy-friendly newsletter and videos and to plug his work on social media.

Some recent headlines on stories in the group's newsletter include, "Kennedy isn't the problem at CDC"; "Axios and other media throw wild punches at Kennedy and MAHA, miss targets"; and "What Kennedy's critics don't want you to know about vaccines, liability and conflicted science."

The robust outside support, unusual for a Cabinet secretary, shows how Kennedy and his supporters are trying to reshape the public's consciousness of health as much as the government's role in it.

"The leaders and funders in that [MAHA] INFLUENCERS, Page A6

On-off-on funding roils diabetes study

Three-decade-old research resumes after setbacks

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

The Trump administration's restoration of federal research funding to Columbia University has revived a landmark diabetes study that has tracked patients for nearly 30 years and vastly expanded understanding of the disease, its treatment, and its prevention.

The study, which has been led by a Harvard Medical School professor since it began in 1996, was forced to shut down for nearly five months after the Trump administration froze funding for Columbia, the manager of a federal grant distributed for Type 2 diabetes research across the country.

Scientists are jubilant at the opportunity to resume their work, said Dr. David Nathan, the Harvard researcher leading the diabetes study, but the funding halt set back the latest phase of the research: exploring potential connections between

DIABETES STUDY, Page A6

As preliminary looms, a campaign feel

At Labor Day parade and with Kraft in the crowd, Wu uses platform to push record, rally supporters against Trump

By Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

Officially, it was a Labor Day speech.

But with just a week before Boston's Sept. 9 preliminary election, the event midday Monday took on the tone of a raucous campaign rally, as Mayor Michelle Wu took the stage on City Hall Plaza to tout her record,

►Unions took their protests to the streets. B1.

attack the Trump administration, and rail against her main opponent for mayor, Josh Kraft.

"We will not back down — not to scare tactics, not to political stunts, and not to billionaires trying to buy power and sell out our communi-

ties," Wu said, as attendees cheered and beat drums.

If Labor Day weekend is the unofficial end to summer, in Boston this year it also marked the start of the final sprint toward Election Day. After a sleepy summer during which few voters were closely attuned to politics, mail-in ballots are out and early voting launched this weekend in the city, with candidates flocking to polling places to try to drum up support. As children return to school this week and the weather begins to signal fall, the leading mayoral candidates will compete in forums Tues-

day and Wednesday, in final efforts to collect voter support ahead of next week's vote.

Wu, Kraft, and two others — perennial candidate Robert Cappucci and community activist Domingos DaRosa — are competing next week in the first round of voting for Boston mayor. The top two vote-getters will proceed to November's election. Every city councilor is also on the ballot this fall.

For many candidates, Monday's parade was an opportunity to fly banners, wield signs, and rally sup-

WU, Page A7

DEVASTATION IN AFGHANISTAN



WAKIL KOHSAR/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

An earthquake and landslides killed hundreds of people and isolated battered villages in eastern Afghanistan early Monday. Houses throughout the region were destroyed, including this one in the district of Nurgal in Kunar Province. A3.

Israeli offensive advances in Gaza City

Dozens killed as famine reportedly takes hold; scholars accuse nation of genocide

By Wafaa Shurafa, Samy Magdy, and Sam Metz
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DEIR AL-BALAH, Gaza Strip — Israel launched strikes across the Gaza Strip on Monday, killing at least 31 people as it pressed ahead with a major offensive in the territory's largest city, according to health officials. Leading genocide scholars, meanwhile, accused Israel of genocide, allegations the govern-

ment vehemently rejects.

Airstrikes and artillery shelling have echoed through Gaza City since Israel declared it a combat zone last week. On the city's outskirts and in the Jabaliya refugee camp, residents have observed explosive-laden robots demolishing buildings.

"Another merciless night in Gaza City," said Saeed Abu Elaish, a Jabaliya-born medic sheltering in the

northwestern side of the city.

Hospitals in Gaza said at least 31 people were killed by Israeli fire on Monday, more than half of them women and children. At least 13 people were killed in Gaza City, where Israel has carried out several previous large-scale raids since Hamas-led militants attacked southern Israel to ignite the war on Oct. 7, 2023.

Israel says it only targets militants and blames Hamas for civilian casualties because the militant group — now largely reduced to a guerrilla organization — operates in

densely-populated areas.

Gaza City residents, many displaced by war multiple times, now face the twin threats of combat and hunger. The world's leading authority on food crises said last month that it was in the throes of famine — a crisis driven by ongoing fighting and Israel's blockade, magnified by repeated mass displacement and the collapse of food production.

A total of 63,557 Palestinians have been killed in the war, according to Gaza's Health Ministry, which says another 160,660 people

MIDEAST, Page A4

Shining a light on families' hidden pasts

State proposal backs easier access to records of troubled institutions

By Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

For decades, mysterious connections between her late relatives and one of the most notorious institutions in Massachusetts have haunted Kim Turner.

The Newburyport woman grew up believing the grandfather who died a few months before she was born, William Turner, had been an orphan. Then, in her 20s, her father gave her a book that contained pieces of his family's history. She learned that William, from ages 6 to 12, lived at the Walter E. Fernald Developmental Center, a now-shuttered Waltham home for people with disabilities that became infamous for the abuse inflicted on patients who lived there. Even more surprising, her great-grandmother and William's mother, Bridget Turner, was also at Fernald, admitted nine months after her son.

She was stunned. Her grandfather grew up to be a World War I vet who moved to



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

A family photo of Peg and Bill Turner (left) and Bill as an 18-year-old enlistee.

Portland and made a good living designing dental equipment. She knew of no disabilities that would have caused institutionalization.

Turner, now 49, remains plagued by questions: What brought her progenitors to

such a troubled place? Did they see each other? What were their lives like? How long did they both live at the institution, and why did her great-grandmother stay at Fernald after William left?

RECORDS, Page A7

In the news

The MBTA is expected to transfer duties overseeing its compliance with rules for riders with disabilities to a citizen-led group. B1.

Two noted personal injury law firms proclaim "See you in court" — to each other. D1.

Categories of savvy grocery shoppers can run from the free spirit to the avenger to the couponer. See where you fit in. D1.

The Red Sox inched closer to first place after taking an afternoon series opener, 6-4, against the Guardians. C1.

Crime is high in several cities in states with Republican governors, yet they agreed to President Trump's request to send their National Guard forces to Washington, D.C. A2.

The leaders of China, Russia, and India signaled warm ties at their summit in China. A3.



Glow all the way

Tuesday: Lots of sun, cool. High 69-74, low 55-60.

Wednesday: Lots of sun, warm. High 76-81, low 59-64.

Sunrise: 6:11. Sunset: 7:16.

Weather and comics, D4-5.

Obituaries, C9.

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